SAMPLE CHAPTER · DRAFT FOR EDITORIAL REVIEW

2025: A History

Chapter 1: The Second Presidency

ABOUT THIS DRAFT

This chapter was drafted with Claude, an AI system, from a research dossier of opened primary documents, official statistics and analyses, and is presented to its editor for review. Every footnoted sentence rests on recorded findings; nothing is cited to Wikipedia, which served only as a finding aid. Sources are limited to those published by 31 October 2026.

Status: every footnoted sentence has been checked against the full text of the sources it cites, in a separate verification pass on 21 October 2026. All 44 noted sentences are supported as now worded, after eleven changes. That pass was made by the same AI system, not by a person. The editor's review and sign-off have not yet taken place, and the text should be treated as a draft.

Portraits are engraving-style renderings made by line hatching from the photographs credited at the end, not photographs and not evidence. Figures are drawn from the official data named beneath them.

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The Second Presidency

"Universal injunctions likely exceed the equitable authority that Congress has given to federal courts."

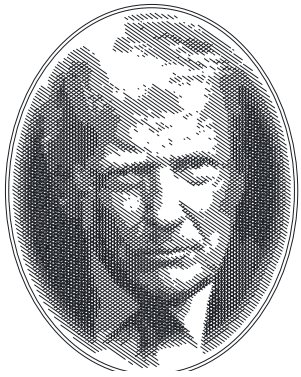
— Trump v. CASA, Inc., 27 June 2025[1]

The first day

On 20 January 2025 President Donald Trump signed a set of orders that announced how he meant to govern.[2] One created a "Department of Government Efficiency," not a department at all but a temporary organization inside the renamed United States DOGE Service, due to expire on 4 July 2026.[3] Every agency was told to set up its own DOGE team of at least four employees within thirty days.[4]

A second order addressed citizenship. It directed federal agencies to stop recognizing as citizens children born in the United States to mothers who were present unlawfully or only temporarily, unless the

[1] Supreme Court of the United States, "Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884," 27 June 2025, Syllabus.
[2] "Executive Order 14158: Establishing and Implementing the President's "Department of Government Efficiency" (90 FR 8441)," 29 January 2025, Heading; "Executive Order 14160: Protecting the Meaning and Value of American Citizenship (90 FR 8449)," 29 January 2025, Heading; "Proclamation 10887: Granting Pardons and Commutation of Sentences for Certain Offenses Relating to the Events at or Near the United States Capitol on January 6, 2021 (90 FR 8331)," 29 January 2025, Heading.
[3] Executive Order 14158, Sec. 3.
[4] Executive Order 14158, Sec. 3(c).



Donald Trump

father was a citizen or a lawful permanent resident, for births more than thirty days after the order.[5] A third act, a proclamation, reached back to the attack on the Capitol on 6 January 2021: it commuted the sentences of fourteen named people and granted "a full, complete and unconditional pardon" to everyone else convicted of offences connected with that day.[6]

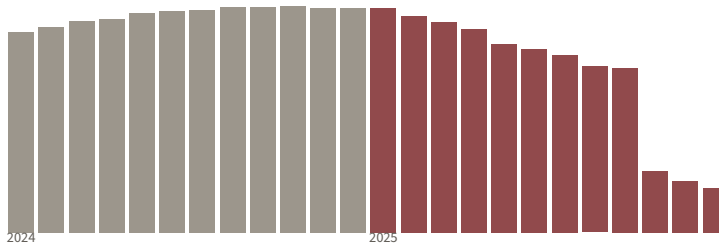
These three instruments set the pattern for the year. Each was an exercise of power by the President alone. Each tested a different limit: the reach of executive reorganization, the meaning of the Fourteenth Amendment, and the pardon power. And each would be contested, in the courts or in public, for months. This chapter follows that contest. It argues that the presidency moved fast and far in 2025, and that the institution that checked it was, above all, the federal judiciary, often late and sometimes in the President's favour.

Cutting the state

The order itself spoke of modernizing federal technology and software.[7] The change in the federal government that can be measured for the year is in its workforce. Federal employment, which stood at 3,010,000 in January, fell in every month of the year that followed and ended it at 2,722,000, a loss of 288,000 jobs.[8]

[5] Executive Order 14160, Sec. 1-2.
[6] Proclamation 10887, Proclamation.
[7] Executive Order 14158, Sec. 4.
[8] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, "Current Employment Statistics, series CES9091000001 (federal government employment, seasonally adjusted)," undated, Monthly values, 2024-2025.

Federal government employment, 2024–2025 (thousands)



Monthly, seasonally adjusted; 2024 in grey, 2025 in red. The axis starts at 2,650,000, not at zero, to show the change. Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics, Current Employment Statistics, series CES9091000001.

The largest single fall came late. In the current series, federal employment fell from 2,914,000 in September to 2,748,000 in October.[9] In its first estimate, published in December, the Bureau of Labor Statistics put the October drop at 162,000 and attributed it to employees who had accepted a "deferred resignation" offer leaving the payroll.[10] By November, it reported, federal employment was down by 271,000 from its January peak.[11] Federal employment ended 2025 nearly a tenth lower than it began.[12]

Deportation and the Alien Enemies Act

On 14 March the President invoked the Alien Enemies Act against the Venezuelan gang Tren de Aragua, which his proclamation described as invading the United States.[13] It declared that Venezuelan citizens aged fourteen or older who were members of the gang, and were not naturalized citizens or lawful permanent residents, were liable to be apprehended, restrained and removed as "alien enemies."[14]

The Supreme Court intervened twice within a week. On 7 April it ruled that men held under the proclamation had to bring their challenges as petitions for habeas corpus in the district where they were confined, which for these detainees meant Texas rather than the court

[9] Current Employment Statistics, series CES9091000001 (federal government..., Monthly values, 2024-2025.
[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, "The Employment Situation, November 2025," 16 December 2025, Establishment survey commentary.
[11] The Employment Situation, November 2025, Establishment survey commentary.
[12] Current Employment Statistics, series CES9091000001 (federal government..., figure calculated from the documents cited.
[13] "Proclamation 10903: Invocation of the Alien Enemies Act Regarding the Invasion of the United States by Tren de Aragua (90 FR 13033)," 20 March 2025, Heading; Sec. 1.
[14] Proclamation 10903, Sec. 1, 3.

in Washington that had first blocked their removal.[15] But it also held that they were "entitled to notice and opportunity to be heard" before removal, so that they could seek habeas relief in time.[16]

Three days later the Court turned to a single case. On 15 March the government had removed Kilmar Abrego Garcia to detention in El Salvador.[17] It acknowledged that an earlier order forbade his removal there, so that the removal was illegal, and attributed it to an "administrative error."[18] A district court in Maryland ordered the government to bring him back. The Supreme Court left the core of that order in place: the government was to "facilitate" his release and ensure that his case was handled as it would have been had he not been improperly sent there.[19] The two rulings framed the year's argument over deportation. The courts allowed the government to pursue its aims, but they insisted on procedure, and the dispute over what "facilitate" required became a measure of how far the administration would go in honouring a court's demands.

Soldiers in American cities

On 7 June, as protests against federal immigration officers grew in Los Angeles, the President called at least 2,000 members of the National Guard into federal service for sixty days, to protect Immigration and Customs Enforcement and other federal personnel and property.[20] He relied on section 12406 of title 10 of the United States Code, and the number federalized reached 4,000.[21]

California sued. Judge Charles Breyer found that none of the conditions the statute requires for federalization existed and that the order had not been issued through the Governor, and he ordered the Guard returned to the Governor's control.[22] On 19 June the Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit stayed his order, holding that the President had

[15] Supreme Court of the United States, "Trump v. J.G.G., No. 24A931 (per curiam)," 7 April 2025, Per curiam.
[16] Trump v. J.G.G., No. 24A931 (per curiam), Per curiam.
[17] Supreme Court of the United States, "Noem v. Abrego Garcia, No. 24A949," 10 April 2025, Order.
[18] Noem v. Abrego Garcia, No. 24A949, Order.
[19] Noem v. Abrego Garcia, No. 24A949, Order and statement.
[20] The White House, "Department of Defense Security for the Protection of Department of Homeland Security Functions," 7 June 2025, Memorandum; United States Court of Appeals for the Ninth Circuit, "Newsom v. Trump, No. 25-3727, order granting stay pending appeal," 19 June 2025, Background.
[21] Department of Defense Security for the Protection..., Memorandum; Newsom v. Trump, No. 25-3727, order granting..., Summary.
[22] Newsom v. Trump, No. 25-3727, order granting..., Summary.

probably acted within the statute.[23] In August the President turned to the capital. An order of 11 August declared a "crime emergency" in the District of Columbia and, under the Home Rule Act, directed the city to place its Metropolitan Police Department at the service of the federal government.[24]

The courts drew a firmer line in Illinois. On 4 October the President federalized 300 members of the Illinois National Guard to protect federal officers in and around Chicago, and on the next day Guard members from Texas were federalized and sent there too.[25] A district court barred their deployment, and the Court of Appeals kept the bar in place.[26] On 23 December the Supreme Court refused to lift it. The statute let the President call out the Guard if he was "unable with the regular forces to execute the laws," and the Court concluded that "regular forces" likely meant the regular military.[27] Because the Posse Comitatus Act generally forbids the military to execute the laws, the President would first need some authority to use the army for that purpose, and the government had identified none.[28] Justices Alito, Thomas and Gorsuch dissented.[29] After months of deployments, the Supreme Court ended the year by holding that, on this statute at least, the President probably could not send the Guard where he had sent it.

Courts and Congress

The courts were the main check on the President in 2025, but the Supreme Court also limited their reach. Opponents of the citizenship order brought three suits, and federal district courts responded with injunctions barring its enforcement against anyone, anywhere.[30] On 27 June, in Trump v. CASA, the Supreme Court held by six votes to three that such "universal injunctions likely exceed the equitable authority that Congress has given to federal courts."[31] Justice Barrett wrote for the Chief Justice and Justices Thomas, Alito, Gorsuch and Kavanaugh;

[23] Newsom v. Trump, No. 25-3727, order granting..., Summary and order.
[24] "Executive Order 14333: Declaring a Crime Emergency in the District of Columbia (90 FR 39301)," 14 August 2025, Sec. 1-2.
[25] Supreme Court of the United States, "Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443," 23 December 2025, Per curiam, pp. 1-2.
[26] Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Per curiam, pp. 1-2.
[27] Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Per curiam, pp. 2-3.
[28] Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Per curiam, pp. 2-3.
[29] Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Order and opinions.
[30] Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884, Opinion, Part I.
[31] Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884, Syllabus.

Justice Sotomayor, joined by Justices Kagan and Jackson, dissented, as did Justice Jackson separately.[32] The Court did not decide whether the citizenship order was lawful; it decided how far a single judge's order could reach.[33]

Congress passed a budget reconciliation act, Public Law 119-21, signed on 4 July.[34] It did not pass the annual budget on time. No regular appropriations had been enacted by the start of the fiscal year on 1 October, and the government shut down.[35] The shutdown ended only on 12 November, when the President signed a law that funded three groups of agencies for the full year and the rest of the government until 30 January 2026.[36] At 42 full days it was the longest funding gap since at least 1977, eight days longer than the previous record set in 2018-2019.[37]

On one subject the House acted almost unanimously. It voted 427 to 1 on 18 November to require the Justice Department to publish its records on Jeffrey Epstein.[38] The President signed the bill the next day; it gave the Attorney General thirty days to make the records public.[39]

What checked the President

The year's record suggests that the second Trump presidency used executive power with a speed and breadth that the courts could only partly follow. Orders on government, citizenship and pardons were signed on the first day.[40] The Alien Enemies Act was used against a criminal gang, and the National Guard was federalized in California and Illinois.[41] Federal employment fell by nearly 300,000.[42]

[32] Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884, Syllabus.
[33] Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884, Syllabus.
[34] U.S. Government Publishing Office, "Public Law 119-21: An Act to provide for reconciliation pursuant to title II of H. Con. Res. 14, 139 Stat. 72," 4 July 2025, Heading.
[35] Congressional Research Service, "Federal Funding Gaps: A Brief Overview (RS20348, updated 18 December 2025)," 18 December 2025, Funding gap history.
[36] U.S. Government Publishing Office, "Public Law 119-37 (Continuing Appropriations, Agriculture, Legislative Branch, Military Construction and Veterans Affairs, and Extensions Act, 2026), 139 Stat. 495," 12 November 2025, Heading; Sec. 106; Federal Funding Gaps, Funding gap history.
[37] Federal Funding Gaps, Funding gap history.
[38] Office of the Clerk, U.S. House of Representatives, "Roll Call 289, H.R. 4405, 119th Congress, 1st Session," 18 November 2025, Vote totals.
[39] U.S. Government Publishing Office, "Public Law 119-38 (Epstein Files Transparency Act)," 19 November 2025, Sec. 2.
[40] Executive Order 14158, Heading; Executive Order 14160, Heading; Proclamation 10887, Heading.
[41] Proclamation 10903, Sec. 1; Department of Defense Security for the Protection..., Memorandum; Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Per curiam, pp. 1-2.

The checks came mostly from judges. They insisted on notice before deportation, required the government to facilitate the return of a man it had deported illegally, and in December held that the Guard could not be sent to Chicago on the President's chosen authority.[43] Yet the Supreme Court also curtailed nationwide injunctions, and an appeals court allowed the Guard to stay federalized in California while the case went on.[44] Congress, for its part, let the government shut down for six weeks and ordered the Epstein files opened.[45] The limits on the presidency in 2025 were real, but they were set case by case, and usually after the fact.

[42] Current Employment Statistics, series CES9091000001 (federal government..., Monthly values, 2024-2025.
[43] Trump v. J.G.G., No. 24A931 (per curiam), Per curiam; Noem v. Abrego Garcia, No. 24A949, Order and statement; Trump v. Illinois, No. 25A443, Per curiam, pp. 2-3.
[44] Trump v. CASA, Inc., No. 24A884, Syllabus; Newsom v. Trump, No. 25-3727, order granting..., Summary and order.
[45] Federal Funding Gaps, Funding gap history; Public Law 119-38 (Epstein Files Transparency Act), Sec. 2.

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ILLUSTRATIONS

Donald Trump. After the official presidential portrait by Daniel Torok, The White House, 2025. Public domain (work of the US federal government). Rendered as line engrav-

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